From Vague to Precise

Immersion Week SF · Day 1 · Session 1.1

35

Minutes

You leave with one precise problem statement

What This Session Covers

01 Problem statements versus solution statements

02 Making Claude interrogate a vague ask

03 The three-gate scoping test

04 Standing up your Claude Project

What are you building?

Two Ways to Answer That

Vague	vs	Precise
An AI thing for resumes		Flags gaps in 200 files

How We Get There

01

Separate

Problem apart from solution

02

Interrogate

Let Claude attack the ask

03

Scope

Run the three-gate test

04

Commit

Write it into the Project

01

Problem, Not Solution

Problem statement

A gap between what happens and what should.

Solution statement

A thing you plan to build, assuming the diagnosis.

How to Tell Them Apart

Problem	Solution
Describes a gap	Describes a build
Admits several fixes	Assumes one fix
Names who suffers	Names a tool

What They Said, What They Meant

Said (solution)	Meant (problem)
Build a RAG chatbot	Staff cannot find answers
Fine-tune a model	Output misses our tone
Make a dashboard	Nobody sees the numbers
Use an agent	Review takes four hours

Why Solution-First Hurts

You cannot tell if it worked

The tool choice is already locked

Scope creeps with no boundary

Feedback arrives too late to use

Three Tells You Wrote a Solution

A tool is named

RAG, agent, fine-tune, dashboard

Only one fix fits

No alternative is even thinkable

No one is in it

Nobody is described as stuck

"Names a tool? Not a problem yet."

- The fastest test in the room

Interrogation

Making Claude attack a vague ask until it is precise.

What Makes Claude Interrogate

Give it the adversarial role

Forbid it from proposing solutions

Demand one question at a time

Make it refuse to move on early

The Interrogation Prompt

You are a skeptical product lead.
My idea: "an AI thing for resumes"

Rules:
- Ask ONE question at a time.
- Never propose a solution.
- Reject vague answers.
- Stop when it is precise.

The Interrogation Loop

01 Answer plainly

No hedging, no tool names

02 Let it push

Expect the follow-up to hurt

03 Restate

Ask Claude to write it back

Before and After the Interrogation

Before	After
An AI thing for resumes	Recruiters miss skill gaps
Who for? Unclear	For 200 intern applicants
Done when? Unclear	Flagged in one pass

Signs It Is Now Precise

A stranger can restate it

You know who is stuck

You can name a wrong answer

Two people would agree it is solved

02

The Scoping Test

Scoping test

Three gates a problem passes before you commit.

The Three Gates

Measurable outcome

You can say whether it worked

Data available

You have it, today, in hand

Three days

Finishable by Friday noon

Gate 1 · Measurable

State up front what would prove it worked.

Vague Metric, Measurable Metric

Vague	Measurable
Better resumes	Flags 8 of 10 known gaps
Faster reviews	Under 30 seconds per file
Higher quality	Two reviewers agree it passes
More useful	Used unprompted twice

Gate 2 · Data

It exists, you may use it, you have it today.

Where Data Plans Die

Access pending

Someone still has to approve it

Wrong shape

Exists, but not in usable form

Too sensitive

Real records you cannot touch

Gate 3 · Three days

The whole path working, not one part polished.

What Three Days Buys

One path

End to end and rough

vs

One part

Polished but alone

Three Candidate Ideas, Three Gates

	Resumes	Policy	Grader
Measurable	**Yes**	Yes	Yes
Data now	Yes	No	Yes
3 days	No	Yes	No

The opposite case

Making Claude argue your problem is the wrong one.

Make Claude Argue Against You

Our problem statement:
"<paste it>"

Argue this is the WRONG problem
for a three-day build.

Three strongest objections,
hardest first. No alternatives.

Running the Opposition

01 Read all three

Do not answer while reading

02 Rank them

Which would actually sink you

03 Fix or accept

Narrow it, or note the risk

When the Objection Wins

Narrow the users, not the ambition

Shrink the data, keep the path

Stub the hard step for now

Change problems only if a gate fails

Cut Scope, Not Ambition

One user type, not four

One input format, not any

One clean path, no edge cases

03

The Team's Shared Brain

Claude Project

A shared workspace holding instructions and context.

Chat Versus Project

A chat	A Project
Context dies at the tab	Context persists
One person holds it	The whole team shares it
Re-explained every time	Explained once

What a Project Holds

Instructions

Standing rules for every chat

Context

Uploaded docs and data

One place

Everyone works from it

Stand One Up Now

01 Create

Name it for the problem

02 Instruct

Paste the problem statement

03 Share

Add every teammate today

Project Instructions Template

Problem
<the precise statement>

Success looks like
<the measurable outcome>

Out of scope
<what we cut, and why>

What to Upload

Sample data, even if faked

The interrogation transcript

The objections you accepted

What Not to Upload

Real personal records

Anything under an NDA

Credentials or API keys

Team Conventions Worth Setting

Convention	What it means
One source	Project over chat
Log it	Decisions land in writing
Shared	Everyone reads it first
Update	Change it when scope does

Project Pitfalls

Instructions written once, never updated

Uploads nobody has actually read

One member still working in chat

Done With This Session When

The statement passes three gates

The strongest objection is answered

The Project exists and is shared

What You Leave With

1

Precise problem

3

Gates passed

1

Shared Project

Next: Mapping the Workflow

Break the problem into steps

Draw it as a Claude Artifact

Name what each step needs